

Primary Source Reading 1: The Opening Debate and the Design Argument

Optima Academy Online / Philosophy & Ethics / High School Honors (9–12) From David Hume's Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion (1779) — text unaltered Read before Lesson 6a: Hume's Method

Before you read: Three friends — Cleanthes, Philo, and Demea — gather at Cleanthes' library for a conversation reported by the young Pamphilus. The conversation opens with a seemingly simple question: at what age should children be taught religion? But the answers reveal three fundamentally different attitudes toward reason and faith that will shape the rest of the dialogue. By the end of this reading, Cleanthes will have stated the argument the rest of the book exists to test.

At What Age Should Religion Be Taught?

DEMEA: The method I follow in their education is founded on the saying of an ancient, "That students of philosophy ought first to learn logics, then ethics, next physics, last of all the nature of the gods." This science of natural theology, according to him, being the most profound and abstruse of any, required the maturest judgement in its students.

PHILO: Are you so late in teaching your children the principles of religion? Is there no danger of their neglecting, or rejecting altogether, those opinions of which they have heard so little during the whole course of their education?

DEMEA: It is only as a science, subjected to human reasoning and disputation, that I postpone the study of Natural Theology. To season their minds with early piety, is my chief care... Having thus tamed their mind to a proper submission and self-diffidence, I have no longer any scruple of opening to them the greatest mysteries of religion.

Philo's Irony: The Limits of Reason

PHILO: Your precaution, of seasoning your children's minds early with piety, is certainly very reasonable; and no more than is requisite in this profane and irreligious age. But what I chiefly admire in your plan of education, is your method of drawing advantage from the very principles of philosophy and learning, which, by inspiring pride and self-sufficiency, have commonly, in all ages, been found so destructive to the principles of religion... Let us become thoroughly sensible of the weakness, blindness, and narrow limits of human reason: Let us duly consider its uncertainty and endless contrarieties, even in subjects of common life and practice... When the coherence of the parts of a stone, or even that composition of parts which renders it extended; when these familiar objects, I say, are so inexplicable, and contain circumstances so repugnant and contradictory; with what assurance can we

decide concerning the origin of worlds, or trace their history from eternity to eternity? (*Part 1*)

[Pamphilus notices that Demea smiles with satisfaction at these words, while Cleanthes smiles with the sense that Philo is up to something. Cleanthes suspects, correctly, that Philo's skepticism about reason is not really an ally of Demea's faith — it undermines confident argument for religion just as thoroughly as it undermines confident argument against it. The conversation continues through Part 1 and into Part 2, where Cleanthes finally states, in his own voice, the argument he thinks reason actually does support.]

Cleanthes States the Design Argument

CLEANTHES: Look round the world: contemplate the whole and every part of it: You will find it to be nothing but one great machine, subdivided into an infinite number of lesser machines, which again admit of subdivisions to a degree beyond what human senses and faculties can trace and explain. All these various machines, and even their most minute parts, are adjusted to each other with an accuracy which ravishes into admiration all men who have ever contemplated them. The curious adapting of means to ends, throughout all nature, resembles exactly, though it much exceeds, the productions of human contrivance; of human designs, thought, wisdom, and intelligence. Since, therefore, the effects resemble each other, we are led to infer, by all the rules of analogy, that the causes also resemble; and that the Author of Nature is somewhat similar to the mind of man, though possessed of much larger faculties, proportioned to the grandeur of the work which he has executed. By this argument a posteriori, and by this argument alone, do we prove at once the existence of a Deity, and his similarity to human mind and intelligence. (*Part 2*)

After you read: Cleanthes has staked out his whole position in one paragraph: nature resembles a machine; machines have intelligent makers; therefore nature has an intelligent maker, on a much grander scale. Notice how confident and complete this sounds on its own. The rest of the *Dialogues* — beginning with Philo's response in the very next lines of Part 2 — is a sustained test of whether that confidence is earned.